

SHOTS FOR SUCCESS

Even as Covid-19 pushed many on the back foot, Serum Institute of India CEO Adar Poonawalla stood up and led the vaccine production in India from the front

By Neetu Chandra Sharma

► **ADAR POONAWALLA CAN** easily be termed as the poster boy of India's vaccination drive. Rising to the challenge posed by the emergence of the Covid-19 pandemic, the Chief Executive of Serum Institute of India (SII) toiled hard to produce Covishield—the first Covid-19 vaccine in India to receive emergency use approval for public use.

Despite this being a golden business opportunity, Poonawalla says he always kept the company's focus on the safety of people. When Covishield was made available to the government initially in January 2021, SII had announced a price ₹400 per dose to states and ₹600 to private hospitals. However, by April 2021, Poonawalla slashed the price per dose to states to ₹300.

Founded in 1966 by Poonawalla's father Cyrus, the biotechnology and biopharmaceuticals company be-

came the world's largest vaccine producer in terms of number of doses produced as of 2020. Currently, the company manufactures 1.5 billion doses of vaccines annually, including 200 million doses of Covishield. Apart from Covishield, it also manufactures vaccines for tuberculosis, polio, etc.

With the pandemic calling for a swift response, SII partnered with British-Swedish pharmaceutical major AstraZeneca, which had already developed a vaccine candidate AZD1222 in partnership with the University of Oxford. SII started manufacturing it under a licence, with Covishield as the brand name. Bolstered by the sales of Covishield, SII's revenues soared—from ₹5,238 crore in 2018-19 to ₹7,201 crore in 2020-21.

The success, however, came with a lot of challenges and labour for the 41-year-old Poonawalla. "In early 2020, when the World Health Organization (WHO) declared Covid-19 a pandemic, we knew very little about the virus. We barely knew what technologies and vaccines would work. The first challenge was to decide whether I should get into this, and risk money, time, and capital resources or not? But as a manufacturer, I wanted to serve my people and my country," he says.

With the decision on producing vaccines done, SII then had to restructure its facilities, add manpower of over 1,000 people, and provide them with adequate training for operating the additional equipment. The challenges, though, had just started.

"Flights were grounded in 2020 and the cargo was limited. Only essential services through diplomatic channels and other ways and means were possible. Getting the equipment was difficult; getting people to instal it was even tougher. But as we overcame challenges, we started stockpiling the doses ahead of time. That is what really differentiated us from anyone else. At the end of 2021, we delivered 1.5 billion doses, which is more than anyone else," says Poonawalla.

The winner of the Special Jury Award in the BT-PwC India's Best CEOs ranking credits his employees for achieving this mammoth feat in such difficult times. "Handling the challenges of this magnitude with the kind of ethical and moral responsibility was extremely stressful, but I managed to compartmentalise each challenge every day and thanks to my wonderful team that worked day in and day out, we dealt with it all," says Poonawalla, who took the reins at SII as CEO in 2011. Soon after, he played a pivotal role in the acquisition of Biltoven Biologicals, a Netherlands-based government vaccine manufacturing company. He was also in-

Special Jury Award

Adar Poonawalla

CEO, Serum Institute of India

Revenue from operations	7,201
Profit before tax	4,908
Profit after tax	3,891
RoE (%)	19.57

● Standalone results; all figures for FY21 in ₹ crore except RoE

● Data Source: ACE Equity